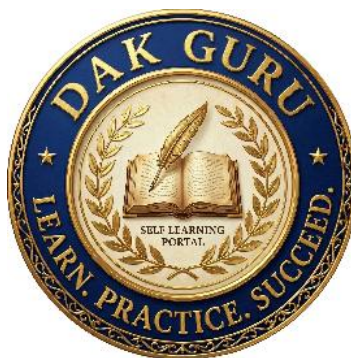


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POSTAL MANUAL VOLUME IV

Establishment • Examinations • Recruitment • Transfers

Comprehensive Study Notes for LDCE Inspector of Posts & PS Group 'B' Examinations

Updated & verified against the latest orders, notifications and circulars

DISCLAIMER

This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and to incorporate the most recent changes, amendments and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules and Regulations in force, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and aspirants are strongly advised to refer to the official Government gazettes, Departmental orders and primary sources for the most authoritative and up-to-date position before relying on any provision for official or examination purposes. Dak Guru accepts no liability for any loss or consequence arising from the use of this material.

Chapter 1 — Establishment Norms and Reviews

This chapter deals with how the staffing strength (“establishment”) of postal units is proposed, justified, sanctioned, recorded and periodically reviewed. “Establishment” simply means the sanctioned posts and their associated cost — the people and money required to run an office. The rules below set out who may move a proposal, how far in advance, what financial detail it must carry, and how often the workload of each unit is re-examined.

1. General Procedure for Establishment Proposals

1.1 Who submits and to whom

Every proposal framed by a **Divisional Head of Postal/RMS**, a **Chief Postmaster**, or an **Executive Engineer/Superintendent Engineer** must be forwarded by the **Head of the Circle** directly to the **Director General**. The Head of the Circle forwards the papers to the sanctioning authority **in consultation with the Circle Internal Financial Advisor (IFA)**, so that the financial angle is examined before the file moves up.

1.2 Proposals routed through specialised wings

Proposals that concern **Business Development (BD) & Marketing**, **Postal Life Insurance (PLI)**, **the Postal Directorate**, or **the Civil Wing** must be channelled through the respective **Chief General Managers (CGMs)**, **Deputy Directors General (DDGs)**, or **Chief Engineers (Civil)**, as the case may be. This ensures the proposal is vetted by the wing that owns the subject before it reaches the sanctioning authority.

1.3 Advance timelines

Every proposal must reach the Director General *before the desired date of sanction*, allowing the following minimum lead time:

Type of Establishment	Minimum Advance Notice
Fixed (permanent) establishment	3 months in advance
Temporary establishment	2 months in advance

In cases concerning the **Postal and Railway Mail Service (RMS)**, the proposal must additionally be supported by a **statistical memorandum** and, where necessary, a **copy of the valuation**.

2. Justification and Financial Implications

2.1 Mandatory financial disclosure

Every communication proposing the **creation, revision or abolition** of a fixed establishment must clearly explain the grounds for the proposal and spell out its financial effect. The proposal must state:

1. The **present cost** of the establishment (or of the portion affected).
2. The **number and pay** of the posts proposed to be added or modified.
3. The **cost after revision** of the establishment concerned, presented in a *tabular form* so the “before vs after” comparison is clear.

2.2 Four categories of establishment charges

For the purpose of working out cost, establishment charges are grouped into four categories. The first two heads below apply to offices; the next two apply to RMS divisions.

For Head Offices / Large Sub-Offices	For RMS Divisions
Clerical establishment	Sorting Assistant establishment
Delivery establishment	Mail Guards establishment
Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS) — formerly Class IV	Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS)
Contingent allowances, house rent, etc.	Contingent allowance, allowances for attendants at rest-houses, etc.

2.3 Definition of “Office Establishment”

KEY DEFINITION

“Office establishment” includes all non-gazetted servants engaged in clerical duties, as well as MTS employed in offices — but **excludes sweepers**.

2.4 Transfer of establishment charges

When an appointment or charge is to be moved from one office/division to another, a **single proposal** must simultaneously contain both legs of the transaction:

- (a) the **abolition** of the post/charge in the old office or division; and

- **(b) the simultaneous creation** of the post/charge in the new office or division.

2.5 Value Returns

A value return in **Form Est. 5 or Est. 6(a)** must accompany every proposal that involves any of the following:

- Opening an Experimental Post Office.
- Increasing the establishment charge of a Branch Office (BO).
- Converting a Branch Office into a Sub-Office.
- Closing an office on the ground that it is un-remunerative.
- Increasing the cost of mail lines that benefit Branch Offices only.

3. Registers and Periodical Reviews

3.1 Register of Sanctioned Establishments

Divisions must maintain a **Register of Sanctioned Establishments in Form A.C.G. 19(a)**. The same form is used for the corresponding record in Head Offices. This register is the authoritative record of every sanctioned post.

3.2 Periodical review of work

The Head of the Circle arranges to receive work statistics from each Head Office and the larger Sub-Offices at fixed intervals. The review is carried out against the prescribed **Time Tests** (historically “Bewoor’s Time Tests,” now read with the current work-study norms — see the note at the end of this chapter). The standard review cycle is:

Unit Reviewed	Review Interval
All GPOs / Head Offices / MDGs	Every year
LSG / HSG Sub-Offices	Every 3 years
Class I Sub-Offices	Every 3 years
Other Town / Sub-Offices	Every 3 years
Branch Offices	Every 3 years
Allowances of GDS BPMs and other GDS	Every 3 years (revision)

In addition:

- Statistical reviews of **Mail Offices, TMOs, Sub-Record Offices, Record Offices and Sections** must be conducted **every year**.
- The establishment review of **Divisional Offices, Postal Stores Depots (PSD) and Returned Letter Offices (RLO)** is carried out **every 3 years**.

3.3 Road establishment

The road establishment (i.e. the number of **Assistant Branch Postmasters / mail carriers — ABPMs**) for each mail line depends on the **length of the line** and the **weight of mails** carried. Wherever practicable, the *same ABPM should carry mails in both directions* over their stage, to use the resource efficiently.

4. Norms for Opening Branch Post Offices (GDS Posts)

Opening a new Branch Post Office in a rural area is governed by population, distance and anticipated-income criteria. Relaxed thresholds apply to hilly, tribal, desert and otherwise inaccessible areas, recognising that such areas cannot meet the normal density and revenue tests.

Parameter	Normal Areas	Hilly / Tribal / Desert / Inaccessible Areas
Population	3,000 in a group of villages (for a new BO)	500 in an individual village, or 1,000 in a group of villages
Distance	Minimum 3 km from the nearest Post Office	Same 3 km limit; in hilly areas the minimum distance may be relaxed by the Directorate
Anticipated Income	At least 33.33% of the cost	At least 15% of the cost

EXAMINATION TIP

Remember the three numbers for normal areas — **3,000 population, 3 km distance, 33.33% (one-third) income**. For special areas the population test halves/thirds (500 / 1,000) and the income test drops to **15%**.

CURRENCY NOTE — Work-Study Norms (verify before the exam)

The **opening criteria** above (population / distance / income) remain the established basis for sanctioning a new BO. Separately, the Department issued a **revised Work Study Report and norms for Head and Sub Post Offices vide Letter No. 25-11/2019-PE-I/WS dated 27.03.2026**, framed for the APT 2.0 environment, which supersedes the earlier ad-hoc (May 2019) norms and prescribes standard coefficients (HOs 15%, SOs 10%).

Revised **workload norms for Branch Offices** were notified separately thereafter (mid-2026). These govern *staffing/workload measurement*, which is distinct from the BO *opening* thresholds. As work-study norms are periodically updated, confirm the latest Directorate order in force before relying on any specific time factor or coefficient.



Chapter 2 — Experimental Post Offices and Revenue Calculations

An “Experimental Post Office” is opened on a trial basis where the need for postal service exists but the revenue is not yet proven. The rules below govern how long such an office may run on trial, when it can be made permanent, and how the “income” of any post office is computed for the purpose of these tests. The income figures matter because the decision to continue, close or make an office permanent turns on whether it earns enough to justify its cost.

1. Regulations for Experimental Post Offices

1.1 Sanction period

No experimental Post Office, Postman or Village Postman may be sanctioned for a period **exceeding 6 months at a time**. A further extension may be sanctioned **only** if there is a **reasonable expectation that the office will become self-supporting within 2 years**.

1.2 Permanency criteria

Except for experimental offices opened in **large towns**, no experimental office may be made **permanent** unless its **total income covers its total cost plus 25% of the cost**. In other words, it must earn at least **125% of its cost**.

1.3 Closure of unremunerative offices

If an experimental office in a village remains **unremunerative even after 24 months (2 years)**, the office **may be closed**.

1.4 Procedure for opening

Once the Superintendent’s proposal for an experimental Post Office is approved, the **Head of Circle (HOC)** issues an order to the Superintendent to open the office for a period of **6 months**. A copy of this order is sent **simultaneously to the Head Office and the Audit Office**, so that both the operating and the audit sides are aware from day one.

QUICK RECAP — The “6 / 24 / 25” rule set

Sanction at a time: 6 months | Trial limit before closure: **24 months** | Income needed for permanency: **cost + 25%**.

2. Calculation of Office Income

For both rural and urban post offices, “income” is not simply the cash handled — it is computed by applying prescribed percentages to commissions and prescribed flat rates to savings/scheme transactions. The components are:

2.1 Commission-based components

Item	Income Reckoned
Money Orders — Issued	24% of the commission realised
Money Orders — Paid	38% of the commission that would have been realised
Indian Postal Orders — Sold	2/5th (40%) of the commission realised
Indian Postal Orders — Paid	2/5th (40%) of the commission that would have been realised
Other Agency Functions	1% of the total income on other items (postage, money orders, postal orders, savings bank and certificates) where performed

2.2 Reimbursement rates for Savings & Schemes

For Savings Bank and Savings Certificate work, the post office earns a fixed **agency remuneration per account/transaction**, fixed by the Ministry of Finance. The rates below were first notified for FY 2023-24 and have been **carried forward unchanged** for the subsequent years (see currency note):

Item / Category	Rate	Basis
POSB — Live (Savings Deposit) account	Rs. 219.23	per account, per annum
POSB — Silent account	Rs. 35.61	per account, per annum
Savings Certificate transaction (NSC & KVP)	Rs. 73.92	per transaction
Indira Vikas Patra (IVP)	Rs. 19.59	per unit

Item / Category	Rate	Basis
MGNREGA wage payment	Rs. 24.88	per active account per annum (work done by BO; reimbursed by Ministry of Finance / MoRD)

CURRENCY NOTE — Savings remuneration rates (VERIFIED)

The four savings/certificate rates above (Rs. 219.23 / Rs. 35.61 / Rs. 73.92 / Rs. 19.59) were notified by the Ministry of Finance, Department of Economic Affairs (Budget Division), vide **O.M. No. 9/4/2023-NS dated 18.12.2023** for FY 2023-24, and were **retained at the same level** in the subsequent estimates conveyed vide **O.M. No. 9/4/2024-NS** (RE 2024-25 and BE 2025-26). They therefore remain the rates in force at the time of writing.

The **MGNREGA figure (Rs. 24.88)** is an *agency commission* payable to the post office for disbursement work and is distinct from the *worker's wage rate*, which is notified state-wise by the Ministry of Rural Development and revised annually (w.e.f. 1 April each year). Agency-commission rates are reviewed periodically — always confirm the latest Finance/MoRD order before quoting a figure in official work.



Chapter 3 — Rules Relating to Departmental Examinations

Departmental examinations are the route by which serving staff qualify for promotion or for entry to higher cadres. This chapter sets out how such examinations are notified, scheduled and conducted; how integrity is safeguarded (OMR cross-checking, CCTV, action on unfair means); how records are preserved; and which level of officer may set the question papers for each cadre.

1. Conduct of Examinations

1.1 Notice of examination

An advance notice of **not less than 40 days** must be issued for every departmental examination, so that eligible candidates have adequate time to apply and prepare. The notification must indicate the number of vacancies category-wise as per the Recruitment Rules.

1.2 Scheduling

Examination dates must be chosen carefully to **avoid clashing with important festivals (national or regional) and national holidays**, so that no section of candidates is disadvantaged.

1.3 Applications and marks

All applications relating to a departmental examination (for example, re-totalling) must be submitted **through the proper channel**. Candidates may also seek **communication of their marks through a Right to Information (RTI) application**.

1.4 Withdrawal of candidature

Permission to withdraw candidature may be granted by the **same authority that granted permission to appear** for the examination.

1.5 Withdrawal after roll-number assignment

Once roll numbers have been assigned, a candidate is **generally not permitted to withdraw** — except in circumstances genuinely beyond their control.

1.6 Evaluation integrity (OMR cross-check)

To assure the accuracy of mechanical (OMR) evaluation, a **cross-check of 10% of the OMR sheets** must be carried out by **manual evaluation** through a nominated Committee or set of Officers.

1.7 Declaration of results

Results should preferably be declared **within 60 days** from the date the examination is held.

1.8 Revaluation

IMPORTANT

Revaluation of answer scripts is **NOT permissible** in any case or under any circumstances.

2. Record Preservation and Security

Different categories of examination record carry different mandatory retention periods. Keeping these straight is a frequent examination point.

Record	Preservation Period	Reckoned From
OMR sheets & Answer Books	12 months (1 year)	Date of declaration of result
Tabulated result sheets / mark-sheet registers	3 years	Date of announcement of result
CCTV footage of exam halls	2 years	Date of declaration of result
Records of court / vigilance / RTI / disputes	Until finalisation	Then disposed of on orders of the Competent Authority

2.1 Action on unfair means

If a departmental candidate is found guilty of **using unfair means or copying**, the supervising officer must forward a report to the competent authority **to impose a major penalty** on the candidate.

2.2 CCTV surveillance

Examination halls and the Centre Supervisors' offices must be covered by **CCTV recording** (permanently installed or hired). The footage must be preserved in the **personal custody of the DPS (HQ) for 2 years** after the declaration of results.

3. Competent Authorities for Paper Setting

The seniority/level of the officer who may be designated to set the question paper rises with the level of the examination. The prescribed levels are:

Examination / Cadre	Level of Officer (Paper Setter)
Postal Assistant / Sorting Assistant	JAG & above
Postman / Mail Guard	STS / JAG & above
MTS	JTS / STS & above
LDCE — Inspector of Posts (IP)	JAG / SAG
LDCE — PS Group 'B'	HAG

ABBREVIATIONS (officer grades)

JTS = Junior Time Scale | **STS** = Senior Time Scale | **JAG** = Junior Administrative Grade | **SAG** = Senior Administrative Grade | **HAG** = Higher Administrative Grade.



Chapter 4 — Recruitment, Appointment, and Transfers

This chapter covers the re-employment of pensioners and age limits, the maintenance of gradation (seniority) lists, the rules that fix seniority, and — most importantly for examination purposes — the detailed framework governing transfers, including transfer at one's own request under Rule-38 and the tenure of sensitive posts.

1. Re-employment and Age Limits

1.1 Re-employment of pensioners

The **Head of a Circle** may sanction the re-employment of pensioners in **non-gazetted posts** under **Article 520(iii) of the Civil Service Regulations (CSR)**. An **appointing authority of gazetted rank** in charge of a Division or a First-Class Head Post Office may also exercise this power, provided the pensioner is re-employed *within their jurisdiction*.

1.2 Suitability for re-employment

No pensioner whose past record or present circumstances are **not fully satisfactory** — especially as regards **financial solvency** — should be considered suitable for re-employment.

1.3 Age-limit relaxation

A candidate who exceeds the prescribed maximum age limit is **not eligible** for recruitment to the cadre concerned. The maximum age limit **cannot be relaxed by the Heads of Circles**. Where no specific delegation exists, the power to relax vests in the **Government**, and every such case must be referred to the **Director-General before recruitment**.

1.4 Age at appointment

No separate sanction is needed where a candidate is **within the maximum age limit at the time of recruitment** but becomes over-aged by the time of *actual appointment*. The age is judged as on the date of recruitment, not appointment.

1.5 Leave Reserve (LR)

A Leave Reserve of assistants **not exceeding 10% of the operative clerical staff** is sanctioned, to cover staff on leave and keep offices functioning.

2. Maintenance of Gradation Lists

A “gradation list” is the official seniority list of officials in a cadre. Its accuracy decides promotions, so the rules fix who publishes it, how often, in what form, and how errors are corrected.

Gradation List	Compiled / Published	Reference
Circle gradation list	Once in 5 years (corrected up to 1st July)	Rule 32-A
Divisional gradation list	Once in 3 years	Rule 32-B

2.1 Format

All gradation lists are maintained in **Form App. 44**. Within each list the names of officials of each class are entered **separately and in strict order of seniority**, with one or more pages left blank after each class for future updates.

2.2 Rectification of errors

If a gradation list contains a mistake, the official(s) concerned must point it out to the Authority for rectification **within one year** of the date of issue of the list.

3. Seniority Rules

3.1 Recruitment through examination

- If the examination is **competitive**, seniority follows the **order of merit** in that examination.
- Where recruitment is **partly from departmental candidates and partly from outsiders**, the **departmental candidates always rank senior** to the outsiders.

3.2 Recruitment by promotion

- If promotion is by **pure selection**, seniority follows the **order of preference**.

4. Transfer Guidelines

4.1 General liability (Rule-37)

All officials of the Department are **liable to be transferred to any part of India** in the interest of service.

4.2 Timing of transfers (Rule-37-A)

Transfers should generally be made in **April** each year, so that the education of school-going children is not dislocated. This restriction does **not apply** in emergent cases or cases of promotion.

4.3 Transfer at own request (Rule-38)

Applications for transfer under Rule-38 — covering Inter-Circle, Intra-Circle and Mutual transfers — must be submitted **through the online system**. The framework is as follows.

(a) Eligibility

An official must complete **one year of service** to be eligible. The one-year condition is **waived** where the spouse/dependent children suffer from a **terminal illness**, or where the appointment is on **compassionate grounds**.

LEGISLATIVE / CADRE NOTE — IP & ASP Inter-Circle Transfer (UPDATED)

Inspectors of Posts (IP) and **Assistant Superintendents of Posts (ASP)** are eligible for Inter-Circle transfer under Rule-38 (under the centralised cadre-management framework introduced vide DoP letter dated 15.02.2023, with further instructions on 03.07.2023).

With effect from 01.06.2024, the Department **removed the minimum one-year service condition** for IP/ASP — so officials with less than one year of service in the cadre can now submit Inter-Circle transfer requests on the Rule-38 portal (DoP letter of even number dated 27.05.2024). Inter-se priority of such requests is fixed as per the All-India Seniority List / examination seniority as detailed in that order. Subsequent clarifications (e.g. 19.07.2024 and the amendment of February 2026 on grounds-based preference and pendency of disciplinary proceedings) should be read together for the current position.

(b) Frequency

- An official is eligible for **two Inter-Circle** and **two Intra-Circle** transfers during the entire service.
- A mandatory gap of **3 years** is required before a **second transfer in the same category**. (No such gap applies when switching to the other category.)
- **PwBD (Persons with Benchmark Disabilities) candidates** are entitled to **one additional chance** in both categories.

(c) Withdrawal and decline

- An employee may **withdraw the request on the online portal at any time**.
- A provisionally-approved transfer may be **declined on the portal within 72 hours** of allotment.
- If an employee cancels an approved transfer **after the 72-hour window** or after the final order is issued, they are **deemed to have availed one chance** of transfer (but no 3-year gap is then imposed for re-applying in the same category).

(d) Competent authority

Type of Transfer	Competent Authority
Inter-Circle	CPMG of both Circles
Intra-Circle (change of Region)	CPMG
Intra-Region	PMG

(e) Cycle

Requests are considered on a periodic basis. The Manual provision refers to a **half-yearly cycle in March and September**, with requests received up to the preceding month included in the priority list.

CURRENCY NOTE – Transfer cycle

The current Rule-38 guidelines (DoP order dated 03.02.2023 and subsequent instructions) provide for transfers to be considered on a **quarterly basis** — on the basis of actual vacancy at the start of **March / June / September / December**. Where a specific examination cycle is involved, additional restrictions on Inter-Circle/Intra-Circle transfer of PA/SA and MTS/Postman/Mail Guard apply after issue of the examination notification. Confirm the cycle currently notified for your cadre before acting.

(f) Relieving norms

Relieving shall **not be denied solely on the ground of staff shortage** if the working strength of the cadre in the Division/Unit is **not less than 66.66%** of the sanctioned strength.

(g) Relieving timeline

An official approved for transfer must **invariably be relieved within 30 days** of the issue of the order. This may be extended to a **maximum of 60 days** on the written request of the official.

5. Tenure and Officiating Arrangements

5.1 Officiating arrangements

Rule 50 of Postal Manual Vol. IV provides for officiating arrangements for **short-term vacancies for a period not exceeding 4 months**.

5.2 Tenure of posts

Tenure Type	Maximum Duration	Applies To
Post tenure	3 years at a time	Superintendent of Post Offices / RMS; Inspector of Posts / RMS (except under special conditions)
Station tenure	6 years	Maximum tenure at one station

EXAMINATION TIP — Key Rule-38 numbers to memorise

2 + 2 transfers (Inter + Intra) | **3-year** gap for same category | **72 hours** to decline | **66.66%** working-strength floor | **30 days** (extendable to **60**) to relieve.

— End of Notes —

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HOW TO USE THIS BOOKLET

Read each chapter's opening paragraph first — it frames what the rules are about. Focus your memory on the highlighted figures and the "Examination Tip" boxes, which capture the points most frequently tested.

Wherever a "Currency Note" appears, the underlying order is liable to periodic revision; before quoting any rate, threshold or cycle in official work or in the examination hall, confirm the latest Directorate / Ministry order in force.